

Nicholas Corbet

E299 – Engineering Professionalism and Ethics

Prof. Olgun Sadik

Oct. 15th 2025

Individual Reflection on AI Ethics

E299 was a class for aspiring engineers to learn more about the positive and negative impacts of artificial intelligence. Through the class readings and in-class discussions, I gained a deeper understanding and appreciation for the importance of artificial intelligence regulation and for having good guidelines in academic settings to preserve academic integrity and make sure students use AI to help them learn, not just as a way to cheat. Before this class, I honestly didn't think that AI ethics or guidelines were that important. I mostly just wondered about copyright issues and who would be held responsible if an AI committed a crime. But through the readings and class discussions, I learned how important it is to have restrictions on AI companies and to give clear guidelines for users of AI, specifically at Indiana University and for the student body. Through this course, I learned that AI regulation and ethics are essential for responsible engineering, sustainability, and accountability.

Before this class, I didn't give much thought to AI ethics. The only things that would cross my mind were science fiction AI movies where the world has been taken over by technology and we are all living in an oppressive dystopian future, and also the issue of AIs being trained with copyrighted material and whether artists had the right to sue an AI company for copyright infringement. But through articles like *"When AI Gets It Wrong: Addressing AI Hallucinations and Bias"* and our in-class discussions, my mind was opened to the importance

of taking AI ethics more seriously now to prevent the unchecked and unregulated growth of AI systems from destroying the environment, poisoning people, replacing jobs, and harming artists. We also learned the importance of having guidelines and ethical use of AI for students to protect sensitive information and maintain academic integrity. A few of the articles talked a lot about the inherent biases that AIs can have baked into their training data and how that can reinforce hateful and harmful stereotypes, but the wide range of training data can also unlock a lot of useful information for many people—for example, doctors can use it to help treat certain minorities that they themselves might not be well educated on. This helped me realize that engineers have a large responsibility to make the tools they develop fair and accessible to all, and open to correction when problems arise that affect certain groups of people. I will take these lessons I've learned into my personal and professional life—keeping my personal information safe from AIs and, in my career, when I work on AI systems, trying my best to be as inclusive as possible and avoid bias as much as I can.

To be an engineer, the job isn't just to design and make things, but to be aware of the impacts of the things you are making on the people they're going to serve. If you were an engineer tasked with making a bridge, you would have to understand the impact your decisions will have on traffic, pedestrians, safety, and the environment. When it comes to engineering AI systems specifically, they must be transparent with their intentions and the steps in their plan, be aware of their environmental impact and minimize it as much as possible, and be fair—building systems that are accessible to all and free from bias. Unlike other engineers who work on bridges or machines, AI can cause harm through data misuse, bias, and the spread of misinformation. This class has helped me understand my role in considering the long-term social effects of the things I create and the projects I associate myself with—not just asking myself *can I build this*, but *should I*, and *who might it affect*. I learned that ethics and engineering go hand in hand, affecting every decision I make.

The course did a good job of opening my eyes to the importance of ethics in AI and let me explore new ideas and challenge existing ones in discussions with my classmates. I liked the readings we did and posting ideas about them and having discussions about them on Canvas, but I do wish I had made more of an effort to speak in class. Creating an environment where students feel more comfortable sharing ideas in person would help a lot—whether that's by having smaller groups of five or six friends where everyone gets time to speak, and people can respond, ask questions, or add onto ideas. An approach like this, I think, would bring more students into the conversation. I also think bringing in students from different programs, like business or art, would be really good for adding new perspectives and ideas. Classes like these are a great step toward preparing us to use AI responsibly, but continuing to improve them and include more perspectives will make future engineers even more prepared to handle ethical challenges.